DAYTRIP / PRODUCT POLICY SERIES

A responsible day-trip planner

Product policy and operating guidance for planning, recommendations, local search, and booking hand-offs

Purpose
A practical policy baseline for the Daytrip demo: accurate recommendations, transparent estimates, careful data handling, safer travel guidance, fair interface choices, accessible use, and accountable service operations.

Prepared for the Daytrip Planner application | Source review date: 1 November 2026

Assumed context: an India-focused day-trip planner that collects destination/date/budget inputs, uses third-party attraction, weather and route data, generates itinerary suggestions, and may hand a user to a separate booking service.

How to read this guide

This document combines product recommendations with summaries of selected official sources. The recommendations are design and operating controls. They do not by themselves establish that a particular law applies, that Daytrip is compliant, or that a source remains current. Legal scope depends on the actual service, commercial role, users, locations, data flows, contracts, and effective dates.

RAG note
This guide is stored with the local policy PDFs at policy_service/documents/daytrip_planner_policy_guide_2026.pdf. The Policy Service will extract its pages and include them in the local search index after restart.

Executive summary

Use the following operating commitments as the product baseline. Treat them as requirements for product design and review, while confirming legal obligations separately for each launch market and business model.

- Be clear about what Daytrip does: it proposes a plan. It does not confirm opening hours, ticket availability, route conditions, safety, accessibility, or prices unless a source and a current verification step support that exact claim.
- Show estimates, source names, and freshness. Keep travel-time, weather, attraction, and generated itinerary information visibly qualified and easy to verify.
- Collect the minimum data needed. Explain what is sent to external providers and model APIs, set retention periods, protect logs and credentials, and implement user rights and breach processes as applicable.
- Make every purchase or booking hand-off explicit. Show total price and terms before commitment, require an affirmative user action, and never imply a booking is confirmed until the booking provider confirms it.
- Design against manipulative patterns. Do not hide fees, preselect paid choices, invent urgency, shame users who decline, or make cancellation materially harder than purchase.
- Prioritize safe and inclusive travel suggestions. Identify adventure risk, flag uncertainty, respect local rules and protected sites, and offer alternatives where accessibility or physical demands matter.
- Treat prompts, retrieved documents, tool results, and model output as untrusted. Validate structured data, fail safely, and keep a human in control of consequential decisions.

Guide map

- 1. Product boundary and user promise
- 2. Truthful recommendations, estimates, and sources
- 3. Consumer fairness and booking hand-offs
- 4. Privacy and data handling
- 5. Safety, accessibility, and responsible travel
- 6. AI, RAG, and external-data controls
- 7. Operations, complaints, and release checks
- 8. Applicability and legal-change notes
- Appendix A. Release checklist
- Appendix B. Official source register

1. Product boundary and user promise

Daytrip accepts a destination and trip constraints, queries selected data providers, and creates a suggested itinerary. The existing demo also includes a policy-source search and a dummy booking-service integration. These features should be described separately so that an itinerary suggestion is not mistaken for a reservation or a guarantee.

1.1 Tell users what the product can and cannot do

- State that an itinerary is a planning suggestion assembled from the submitted constraints and available external data. State when attraction, route, weather, or price details are estimates or may be stale.
- Identify the service that will actually provide a ticket, tour, venue entry, ride, or other paid service. A Daytrip plan is not itself proof that the third-party service has accepted a reservation.
- Describe the limits of the policy search: it retrieves passages from a locally indexed set of documents, may miss relevant provisions, and does not generate a legal answer.
- Do not call a provider or itinerary "verified", "safe", "guaranteed", "best", or "official" unless the claim is narrowly defined and supported by a current source.

1.2 Separate demo behavior from production commitments

- Mark simulated bookings, sample confirmation numbers, mocked policies, and demo-only payment or cancellation behavior as demonstrations. Do not make a user think a dummy booking is a real purchase.
- When integrating a real booking provider, identify who accepts payment, issues tickets, handles cancellation, answers complaints, and is responsible for the service.
- Keep the user's budget and time constraints visible through planning and provide a clear way to edit or restart the request.

Design rule
A user should be able to tell, before acting, whether an item is a recommendation, an estimate, an advertisement, a provider offer, a booking request, or a confirmed purchase.

2. Truthful recommendations, estimates, and sources

Consumer-protection sources emphasize truthful descriptions and informed choice. For Daytrip, that means communicating the basis, timing, and limits of recommendations rather than presenting generated text as independently verified fact. [S1, S2]

2.1 Attraction and destination information

- Use an attributable source for venue name, location, category, and descriptive facts. Record provider and retrieval time internally so questionable entries can be traced.
- Do not infer that a venue is open, accepting visitors, accessible, child-friendly, or ticketed from its presence in a search result. Link users to the venue or authority to verify current hours, admission rules, closures, permits, and restrictions.
- Avoid fabricating services, facilities, reviews, ratings, safety certifications, or endorsements. Clearly label sponsored or affiliate placements and keep them visually distinct from ranked recommendations.
- Provide a report/correction path for closed, relocated, inaccurate, or unsafe listings. Remove or suppress a listing when its source is stale or reliability is uncertain.

2.2 Weather and route information

- Show a forecast timestamp, destination/location, units, and source where available. Weather providers combine forecast models that update on different schedules; a forecast is not a guarantee. [S12]
- Use weather information as a planning aid. Do not give emergency warnings or claim a route is safe based only on a general forecast. Direct users to local authorities for severe weather, air-quality, flood, fire, or trail closure notices.
- Describe routing times and distances as estimates. Traffic, closures, road restrictions, transit schedules, and local conditions can change. Do not imply turn-by-turn navigation or real-time traffic if the application does not provide it.
- If an external provider times out or returns invalid data, say that information is unavailable. Do not silently substitute invented values or claim that a lookup succeeded.

2.3 Price and budget representation

- Label an itinerary budget as a target or estimate. State what it includes and excludes: transport, tolls, parking, admission, food, taxes, service charges, booking fees, and currency conversion may not be included.
- Do not state a venue price unless the price has a source and a relevant retrieval date. Link to the provider for current prices and ticket terms.
- If a paid service is offered, present the complete payable amount, including mandatory fees and taxes, before the user commits. Do not introduce charges only after the user has invested time in a flow. [S2]
- Never invent a discount, limited slot, expiring offer, scarcity message, or savings comparison. Where prices are supplied by a third party, attribute them and explain that the provider controls final price and availability.

3. Consumer fairness and booking hand-offs

The Consumer Protection Act, 2019 addresses consumer interests, misleading representations, and unfair trade practices. The E-Commerce Rules apply to specified online goods and services transactions, including certain cross-border offerings. Whether and how they apply to Daytrip depends on the service's commercial role and transaction flow; obtain a role-specific legal review before launch. [S1, S2]

3.1 Clear commercial information

- Before purchase, identify the seller/service provider and make material terms easy to find: description, total price, what is included, delivery or visit dates, cancellation/refund conditions, support contact, and any important limitation.
- Disclose ranking factors that materially affect results, including paid placement or commercial relationships. Distinguish ads from organic trip suggestions.
- Do not imply Daytrip controls a third-party venue's hours, ticket inventory, transport operations, or refund decision unless it actually does.
- Do not publish fake reviews or use generated testimonials as if they came from real travellers. Moderate reviews under a transparent policy and disclose incentives.

3.2 Booking consent and confirmation

- A booking or paid add-on must require an explicit affirmative action from the user. Do not use pre-ticked boxes, hidden defaults, or consent inferred from continued browsing. [S2]
- Show a review screen with provider, date/time, party size, total amount, and key terms before the final submit action. Let the user correct mistakes before committing.
- Represent states accurately: "request sent", "awaiting provider", "proposal", "confirmed", and "failed" are different states. Show a provider confirmation only after receiving and validating it.

- Keep booking acceptance separate from policy search and itinerary generation. Never let generated itinerary text authorize a purchase.

3.3 Refunds, cancellation, and complaints

- Show cancellation deadlines and refund rules before booking, name the party responsible for refunds, and link the applicable provider terms. Avoid generic promises where provider rules vary.
- Make cancellation/support instructions findable and usable. Do not make cancellation materially more difficult than purchase or use obstruction, trick wording, nagging, or confirm-shaming patterns. [S5]
- Acknowledge a complaint, provide a reference or follow-up path, and direct the user to the seller or authority that can resolve it. Preserve relevant records according to a documented retention schedule.
- Do not tell a user that a payment was refunded until the payment/booking provider confirms that state.

3.4 Dark-pattern review

- Review every funnel for false urgency, basket sneaking, confirm shaming, forced action, subscription traps, interface interference, bait-and-switch, drip pricing, disguised advertisements, nagging, trick wording, and rogue malware patterns identified in the 2023 CCPA guidance. [S5]
- Test both choices: accept and decline should be comparably clear; optional extras should be off unless actively chosen; final price should not rise through undisclosed steps.
- For services that qualify as e-commerce platforms, review the CCPA self-audit advisory and confirm whether current audit or declaration requests apply. Do not assume the advisory applies identically to every trip-planning tool. [S9]

4. Privacy and data handling

Daytrip inputs such as destination, date, budget, and group size can become personal data when linked to an identifiable user or account. The DPDP Act and Rules have staged commencement dates. As of this guide's review date, the Act's 13 November 2025 commencement notification schedules some provisions at publication, some after one year, and a large set after eighteen months. Confirm the provision-by-provision timeline before treating a duty as currently effective. [S6, S7, S8]

4.1 Map and minimize data

- Maintain an inventory of every field collected, where it is stored, which external provider receives it, why it is used, and when it is deleted.
- Ask only for fields needed to plan the trip. Do not request exact home address, identity documents, health information, or children's details unless a defined feature truly needs them and a reviewed process exists.
- Explain when destination and dates are sent to geocoding, attraction, weather, route, or model providers. Offer an alternative when a provider call is not necessary.
- Avoid retaining raw questions or trip details in technical logs by default. Aggregate diagnostics where possible and redact identifiers, access tokens, and payment references.

4.2 Notices, choices, and user requests

- Provide an understandable privacy notice before collection. Describe data categories, purposes, sharing, retention, contact route, and available user rights in language suitable for the product audience.
- Where consent is the applicable legal basis, make the choice specific and affirmative, do not bundle unrelated purposes, and make withdrawal practical. Do not use a policy-search question to authorize marketing or booking.
- Set up a reliable way to handle access, correction, deletion, grievance, and withdrawal requests as required by the provisions in force and the product's commitments.

- If the product is likely to be used by children, conduct a dedicated review of age scope, parental consent/verification, tracking, targeted advertising, and child-safety obligations. Do not assume the phased DPDP regime means no preparation is needed.

4.3 Retention, security, and incidents

- Publish and implement retention periods for requests, memory/reuse records, logs, bookings, and support cases. Delete or de-identify data when the defined purpose and legal retention needs end.
- Restrict log and database access, encrypt network traffic when deployed, protect secrets in environment/secret storage, rotate credentials, and keep a written incident response procedure.
- Review third-party contracts and data-transfer terms. A provider API key is not a user-data protection plan; send only the necessary request fields.
- Keep a breach playbook that identifies decision owners, containment, evidence preservation, affected systems, user/regulator notification analysis, and communications. Follow the current legal timeline and applicable contractual duties.

Current-law caution
This guide is not a commencement tracker. Use the official Gazette notification and the latest Rules/corrigendum to map each provision to its effective date; the RAG corpus includes the Act, 2025 Rules, corrigendum, and commencement material. [S6-S8]

5. Safety, accessibility, and responsible travel

The Ministry of Tourism's adventure-tourism strategy describes activity-specific risk and the need for providers to manage it. A 2026 Ministry answer states that tourist safety is essentially a State subject and that model adventure-safety guidance is circulated to States/UTs for adoption. A planner should not suggest that a central list or a generated itinerary certifies an activity as safe. [S10, S11]

5.1 Physical safety and activity risk

- Identify activities involving significant physical, environmental, or technical risk. Do not present high-risk adventure activities as ordinary low-effort attractions.
- For high-risk activities, direct users to local/state rules and qualified operators. Encourage checking permits, current weather, operator competence, required equipment, age/fitness conditions, insurance, emergency arrangements, and cancellation terms.
- Do not assert that an operator is licensed, certified, insured, or compliant unless an authoritative current registry or evidence supports that claim. If no verification is available, say so.
- Build realistic travel and rest buffers. Do not invent emergency contacts or imply the application monitors a user's location or can dispatch rescue.
- Respect protected-area rules, site-specific visitor controls, wildlife protections, community practices, and seasonal closures. Link to the competent authority where a rule can change by site or date.

5.2 Accessibility and inclusion

- Ask users whether they want accessibility-aware planning; do not infer disability or medical needs from other information.
- Do not label a site "wheelchair accessible" based only on a map category or free-text description. Attribute the source and list what is unknown: step-free entry, paths, toilets, seating, parking, sensory conditions, and assistance.
- Offer alternatives and let users exclude stairs, long walks, crowds, loud venues, or other constraints without requiring a personal explanation.

- Use readable text, sufficient contrast, keyboard-operable controls, clear focus states, descriptive labels, error messages, and layouts that work at zoom and on small screens. Use WCAG 2.2 as a technical reference; this guide makes no conformance claim. [S13]

5.3 Responsible travel

- Prefer current, permitted routes and visitor information. Avoid encouraging trespass, unsafe shortcuts, wildlife disturbance, littering, or access to culturally sensitive places without consent.
- Where reasonable, show public-transport or lower-impact alternatives, local business options, and respectful visitor guidance. Do not overstate environmental benefits without evidence.
- Use neutral, inclusive language about travellers and local communities. Do not stereotype destinations or assume dietary, cultural, religious, or mobility preferences.

6. AI, RAG, and external-data controls

Daytrip uses generative models and external services for planning, and a separate local RAG service for policy passage retrieval. The following controls preserve the distinction between untrusted inputs, retrieved source text, and product decisions.

6.1 Planner and tool boundaries

- Keep the planner task limited to itinerary drafting from validated trip fields and tool facts. Treat user-supplied instructions, attraction descriptions, and all external text as data, not instructions.
- Validate tool names, arguments, result fields, types, ranges, dates, and size limits in application code. Reject unexpected fields and suspicious or malformed results.
- Do not allow a model to authorize payment, create a booking, change account permissions, or send a message. Use deterministic checks and explicit user confirmation for consequential actions.
- If screening, a provider, a tool, or validation fails, fail closed for the affected action and explain what did not happen. Do not present a failed lookup as a fact.
- Keep prompt-injection screening as a defense layer, not proof of safety. Do not put API keys, internal prompts, or other users data in prompts or outputs.

6.2 Policy RAG result handling

- Only index documents whose publisher, source URL, retrieval date, document identity, and known amendment/effective-date context are recorded.
- Show the document title, issuer, source link, page, excerpt, and freshness/validity notes with every passage. Preserve amendments and corrigenda as linked sources.
- Call the score a similarity score or retrieval confidence, never a probability of truth. Low similarity is not proof of irrelevance; high similarity is not proof of legal applicability.
- Do not generate a legal conclusion from one retrieved passage. Ask users to verify the official source and consult a qualified professional for decisions with legal consequences.
- Because the demo Policy Service is unauthenticated, bind it to loopback only. A network deployment requires authentication, authorization, abuse controls, secure transport, and an operational owner.

7. Operations, support, and governance

Assign named owners to the data flow, source corpus, model configuration, complaint path, and release approval. A policy that has no owner or review cadence is difficult to keep current.

7.1 Ownership and support

- Name a product owner for user-facing promises, an engineering owner for services/data security, a source owner for policy PDFs, and a support owner for complaints and corrections.
- Give users a clear route to report inaccurate attractions, unsafe suggestions, inaccessible listings, incorrect policy excerpts, and booking problems.
- Separate Daytrip support issues from third-party provider disputes and make escalation instructions clear. Track unresolved issues and communicate status.
- Maintain an auditable changelog for policy sources and product rules: what changed, who approved it, why, and when it became effective.

7.2 Source and model maintenance

- Review every source URL periodically and after a known amendment, corrigendum, advisory, or provider change. Record checked date and the next review date.
- For each source, verify that the local PDF opens, text extraction succeeds, page references remain usable, and the displayed validity note is accurate.
- Version the embedding model, retrieval threshold, chunking configuration, and corpus manifest. Rebuild the local index after source or model changes and retain the build result.
- Measure retrieval on representative policy questions, unrelated questions, near-duplicates, and amendment-sensitive questions. A score threshold is a tuning control, not a legal accuracy metric.

7.3 Complaints and incident records

- Keep enough records to investigate a complaint, but do not keep every raw prompt or trip request indefinitely. Document access controls and retention rules.
- For an inaccurate or unsafe recommendation, capture the source and app version, suppress repeat exposure where needed, correct the source/logic, and notify affected users if appropriate.
- For data incidents, follow the incident process in Section 4.3. For a booking dispute, distinguish whether the transaction was real, simulated, pending, or confirmed.

8. Applicability and legal-change notes

This guide assumes an India-focused product and summarizes selected official materials available on 1 November 2026. It does not determine whether Daytrip is a data fiduciary, e-commerce entity, marketplace, advertiser, booking agent, travel agent, or service provider for any law. Those roles depend on facts and contracts, not product labels.

- The E-Commerce Rules describe broad coverage of digital goods and services transactions, but specific duties depend on whether the app is operating an e-commerce facility, what it sells or facilitates, and current amendments. Obtain legal advice before enabling real transactions. [S2-S4]
- The DPDP Act's commencement is staged by Gazette notification. The 2025 Rules and corrigendum should be read together with the Act and commencement materials. Do not infer the operative date from a document's publication date alone. [S6-S8]
- Dark-pattern and advertising requirements depend on statutory definitions, context, and conduct. Treat the practical controls here as product standards even when a particular statutory duty needs legal analysis. [S1, S5, S9]
- Tourist safety rules and operator controls may differ by State, activity, protected site, and season. The Ministry of Tourism materials are source guidance, not a substitute for local law or an operator's safety system. [S10, S11]
- WCAG 2.2 is included as an accessibility engineering reference. This guide does not claim Daytrip meets WCAG or any India-specific accessibility law. [S13]

- Before each production release, check whether official sources have changed. This guide is a versioned snapshot, not an automatically updated legal source.

Escalate for review
Get qualified legal and privacy review before launching real bookings/payments, user accounts, personalized memory, marketing, location tracking, children's features, or service in a new country.

Appendix A. Release checklist

Use this checklist at design review, before launch, and after material changes. Record an owner, evidence, and review date for each item.

Product truth

- [ ] The interface says itinerary suggestions are not bookings.
- [ ] Prices, distances, weather, hours, and availability are labeled with scope, source, and freshness where available.
- [ ] External API failures and stale data are visible; no placeholder is passed off as current fact.
- [ ] Paid placement, affiliate relationships, and provider identity are disclosed.

Consumer choices

- [ ] Total payable amount and material terms appear before a booking decision.
- [ ] Optional paid extras require an explicit choice; no preselected consent.
- [ ] Accept and decline are equally clear, and cancellation/support are easy to find.
- [ ] Real booking status is shown only after provider confirmation; demo booking is labeled as simulated.

Privacy and security

- [ ] A data-flow inventory and privacy notice match actual collection and provider sharing.
- [ ] Retention and deletion schedules cover app state, logs, bookings, and support.
- [ ] Credentials are stored outside source and logs; least-privilege access and incident contacts are defined.
- [ ] Current DPDP commencement dates and obligations have been mapped by counsel/privacy owner.

Safety and access

- [ ] Adventure or high-risk activity suggestions link to relevant current authority/operator checks.
- [ ] Accessibility claims have evidence; unknowns are stated and alternatives are offered.
- [ ] Protected sites and local restrictions link to competent authorities.
- [ ] User can report an unsafe or inaccurate listing and receive an acknowledgment.

AI and RAG

- [ ] User and provider text is treated as untrusted; schemas and limits are enforced in code.
- [ ] Model or tool failures do not authorize booking or turn missing data into asserted facts.
- [ ] Policy results include source, page, validity note, and similarity-score caveat.
- [ ] The corpus manifest includes verified source dates/URLs; amendments and corrigenda are represented.

Appendix B. Official source register

Sources were reviewed on 1 November 2026. The source labels used in the main text point to this register. Links are included for direct verification; consult the current issuing-authority version before relying on any requirement.

[S1] The Consumer Protection Act, 2019

Government of India, India Code / Department of Consumer Affairs. Consumer protection rights; misleading representation; unfair trade practices; service-provider context. Official source

[S2] Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020

Department of Consumer Affairs, Government of India; Gazette notification dated 23 July 2020. Scope includes goods and services bought or sold on digital networks; some duties depend on the platform role and applicable rules. Official source

[S3] Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) (Amendment) Rules, 2021

Department of Consumer Affairs, Government of India. Amends the 2020 Rules; read with the original rules and subsequent updates. Official source

[S4] Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) (Amendment) Rules, 2026

Department of Consumer Affairs, Government of India; published September 2026. Included as a future-effective amendment with stated effective date 1 January 2027; do not treat it as effective earlier. Official source

[S5] Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023

Central Consumer Protection Authority, Government of India; Gazette notification dated 30 November 2023. Defines deceptive interface patterns; implications depend on context and applicable consumer-protection law. Official source

[S6] Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023

Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, Government of India. Core framework for processing digital personal data; commencement is provision-specific. Official source

[S7] Commencement notification for the DPDP Act, G.S.R. 843(E), 13 November 2025

Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, Government of India; Gazette of India. Sets staged commencement dates, including provisions commencing one year and eighteen months after publication. Official source

[S8] Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025 and related documents

Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, Government of India. Official index for the Rules, corrigendum, and enforcement timeline; consult the current official versions. Official source

[S9] CCPA advisory on self-audit for dark patterns, 5 June 2025

Central Consumer Protection Authority, Government of India. Advises e-commerce platforms on dark-pattern self-audits; confirm scope and current directions before applying to a product. Official source

[S10] National Strategy for Adventure Tourism, April 2022

Ministry of Tourism, Government of India. Discusses activity risk, operator risk management, skills, safety frameworks, and state/local roles. Official source

[S11] Lok Sabha answer on adventure-tourism safety framework, 16 March 2026

Ministry of Tourism, Government of India. States tourist safety is essentially a State subject and describes model guidelines circulated to States/UTs for adoption. Official source

[S12] Forecast API documentation and model-update notes

Open-Meteo documentation. Explains model sources, forecast time series, update timing, and possible data delays; source terms and attribution must also be checked. Official source

[S13] Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2

World Wide Web Consortium (W3C), Recommendation dated 12 December 2024. Accessibility guidance organized around perceivable, operable, understandable, and robust content. Official source

Prepared as product policy guidance for the Daytrip Planner demonstration. It is not legal advice, does not create a contractual commitment, and is not a compliance certification.